Week 5: Contributions of Great Scholars to Library and Information Science

Introduction

Library and Information Science (LIS) has developed through the intellectual contributions of several great scholars worldwide. These individuals laid theoretical, practical, and technological foundations that shaped the discipline. In Nigeria, many indigenous scholars have also contributed significantly to the growth of LIS as a profession, field of study, and service enterprise. This week, we will examine the contributions of both international and Nigerian LIS scholars.

International Contributors to LIS

(a) Melvil Dewey (1851–1931): Known as the "Father of Modern Librarianship." Developed the Dewey Decimal Classification (DDC) in 1876, a universal system for organising library materials by subject. Founded the American Library Association (ALA) in 1876 and established the first library school at Columbia University in 1887. Advocated for library standardisation and professional education for librarians.

(b) S.R. Ranganathan (1892–1972): Referred to as the "Father of Library Science in India." Developed the Five Laws of Library Science (1931), which remain a philosophical foundation of LIS:

1. Books are for use.
2. Every reader his/her book.
3. Every book its reader.
4. Save the time of the reader.
5. The library is a growing organism.

Invented Colon Classification, an advanced and faceted system for classifying knowledge.

(c) Charles Ammi Cutter (1837–1903): Developed the Cutter Expansive Classification System. Advanced cataloguing practices, including Cutter Numbers (used in modern call numbers). Advocated for library catalogues that serve the needs of readers.

(d) Jesse H. Shera (1903–1982): American library theorist who introduced the concept of social epistemology (study of the social dimension of knowledge). Worked extensively on the philosophy of information and librarianship in society.

(e) Paul Otlet (1868–1944): Belgian scholar considered a pioneer of documentation and information science. Alongside Henri La Fontaine, developed the Universal Decimal Classification (UDC). Envisioned the concept of a "universal book" and early ideas similar to the World Wide Web.

Contributions of Nigerian Scholars to LIS

(a) Professor Kenneth Dike (1917–1983): First indigenous Vice-Chancellor of the University of Ibadan. A great historian and advocate of libraries. His work and advocacy paved the way for academic libraries and professional training in Nigeria.

(b) Prof. Gabriel O. Alegbeleye: Renowned for his research in library cooperation, information science, and documentation. Contributed extensively to LIS education in Nigeria. Authored textbooks widely used by LIS students.

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(c) Professor Adetoun Ogunsheye (1925–2019): First female professor of library science in Africa. Pioneered children's librarianship and public library services in Nigeria. Advocated for women's participation in librarianship.

(d) Professor Felicia Y. Nwalo: Specialist in library education, information services, and user studies. Published widely on LIS development in Nigeria. Contributed to shaping curriculum for LIS departments.

(e) Professor Samuel E. Ifidon: Known as the "Dean of Library Science in Nigeria." Authored several seminal books, including Modern Theory and Practice of Library Collection Development. Established LIS programmes in Nigerian universities and trained generations of librarians.

(f) Professor Michael N. Oshiname: Contributed significantly to research in information literacy, user studies, and LIS pedagogy. Helped bridge the gap between theory and practice in LIS.

(g) Professor B.B. Ogunsola: Known for research in library automation, cataloguing, and classification in Nigeria. Contributed to advancing technical services in Nigerian university libraries.

Other Notable Nigerian Contributors

Dr. Ladipo Ogunrombi – specialist in reference services and LIS practice.

Professor Chinwe Anunobi – contributed to e-libraries and digital information management.

Professor L.O. Aina – wrote foundational LIS texts in Africa; focused on agricultural information and LIS development.

Prof. Airen Adetimirin

Dr. J.A. Otolo – contributed to cataloguing and library organisation in Nigeria.

Dr. T.M. Salisu

Prof. 'Niran Adetoro

Prof. A.O. Simisaye

Dr. A.F. Awodoyin

Dr. T.A. Osisanwo

Mrs. O.E. Afolabi

Mrs. I.O. Adeyeoye

Summary

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The contributions of both international and Nigerian scholars have given LIS its philosophical roots, classification systems, professional standards, and local adaptations. While global figures like Dewey and Ranganathan shaped universal practices, Nigerian pioneers such as Adetoun Ogunsheye, Kenneth Dike, and Samuel Ifidon contextualised LIS for Africa's unique needs. Together, they form the knowledge base upon which LIS education and practice continue to grow.

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